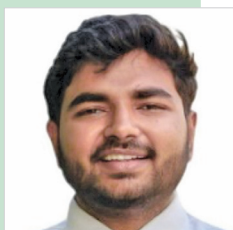


Deep Dive Into UNDERWATER OPTICAL COMMUNICATION— A Comprehensive Overview

A groundbreaking discovery paving the way for high-speed data transmission beneath the waves, eliminating the limitations of acoustic methods!



SURYANSH PRATAP SINGH works as Research Engineer at the Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT), the telecom R&D centre of the government of India. He holds a B.Tech degree in electronics and communication engineering from MNNIT Allahabad



ARKA MUKHERJEE works as Team Leader at the Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT), the telecom R&D centre of the government of India. He has more than eleven years of experience in embedded systems design for optical access networks and quantum key distribution systems

Oceans, covering more than 70% of the Earth's surface, are often referred to as the last frontier of exploration. The underwater world is a realm of breathtaking beauty, wonder, and mystery. It is a world of vibrant marine life, ancient shipwrecks, and unexplored depths. Whether it is the depths of the Mariana Trench or the vibrant coral reefs of the Great Barrier Reef, our fascination with the underwater world knows no bounds. But beneath the serene surface, there is a challenging environment for communication.

Starting from strategic military applications to oil and gas exploration using remotely operated vehicles (ROVs) and autonomous underwater vehicles (AUVs), underwater tourism and marine life exploration require reliable and efficient communication systems. Traditional methods like acoustic communication have limitations, especially when it comes to data transfer rates and bandwidth.

This is where underwater optical communication (UWOC) comes to the fore, providing high data rates, low latency, security, and reliability. At its core, under-

water optical communication harnesses the principles of light propagation and modulation to encode and transmit information.

The architecture of the UWOC system

The main components of an underwater communication system include a transmitter, an underwater channel as the medium for light propagation, and a receiver as depicted in Fig. 1.

Transmitter. The transmitter module consists of a modulator based on the type of application being used and design complexity to modulate the properties of the input optical signal, an optical driver that amplifies, shapes, and controls electrical signals to drive optical components like laser diodes for efficient data transmission in optical communication systems, a light source (LED/laser depending upon the transmission depth), and a lens to focus the modulated optical signal towards the receiver.

Channel. Underwater channels can be broadly classified into four different categories based on different concentrations of dissolved particles, namely pure sea wa-

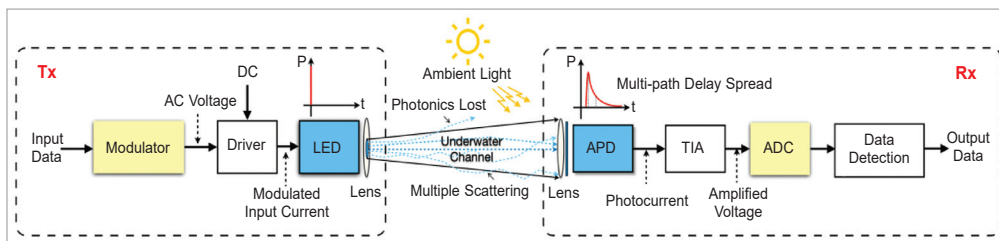


Fig. 1: Block diagram of a UWOC system (Source: <https://www.mdpi.com/1027692>)